Planning independent study and preparation

Practical guide for students | D13-ST

Independent study is the work you do between classes to prepare, practise and check your learning. A realistic plan helps you focus on course priorities and notice when you need support.

1. Find the week's priorities

Check the course site for preparation, readings, practice and deadlines. Separate required work from optional extension activities. Ask which task to prioritise if instructions are unclear.

2. Break work into manageable tasks

Replace "study economics" with a concrete action, such as "read the demand section and explain the graph". Set a goal you can check at the end of the session.

3. Plan realistic study time

Use a weekly timetable that includes classes, work, travel and other commitments. Allow extra time for demanding readings and a buffer before deadlines. Review the plan when circumstances change.

4. Prepare actively for class

Preview headings and key terms, complete the required preparation and note questions. Aim to arrive ready to use the material, even when some points still need explanation.

5. Check what you can do

Close your notes and explain a concept, solve a relevant problem or answer a practice question. Compare your attempt with reliable course material. Use the result to decide what to revisit.

6. Review and adjust

At the end of the week, check what you completed and what remains difficult. Change tasks or timings as needed. Seek help when repeated difficulty is affecting your progress.

7. Example

Instead of planning to "revise all evening", you set aside 40 minutes to explain a supply-and-demand graph and answer two practice questions. You check your answers and record one question about a shift in supply to ask in the next class.

8. Quick checklist

☐ My study tasks are specific.

☐ My timetable reflects my commitments.

☐ I check understanding through practice.

☐ I adjust my plan and ask for help early.

9. When to seek further support

If required work regularly exceeds the time you can manage, discuss priorities and workload with your teacher or adviser. If language demands are a persistent barrier, ask about targeted English-language provision as well as study planning support.

10.Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). Time management. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports recording deadlines, using a weekly timetable and breaking large assignments into achievable tasks.

RMIT University. (n.d.). New ways of learning. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports preparation, independent responsibility and active engagement with university learning. The specific self-check activities are toolkit additions.